



Inspiring Excellence

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Section: 01

Course Title: Emergence of Bangladesh

Course Code: EMB 101

Topic: Research Journal on people's struggle against colonialism and feudalism (Resistance Movements) during the British period.

Faraizi Movement

Haji Shariat Ullah and his son Muhsin, who is familiar with the name, Dudu Miyan in history, led the Faraizi Movement. Haji Shariat Ullah was an Islamic scholar from Faridpur. He completed his education in Mecca. He mainly focused on preaching Islam, teaching Islamic practices and fighting against the unfair Zamindari system, which was initiated to Bengal by the British. After the passing of Shariat Ullah, his son, Dudu Miyan stood in his position and carried on his legacy. Dudu Miyan expanded the Faraizi movement and made it a strong force in rural Bengal against the corrupt Zamindars and the British.

At early 19th century, when Hindu Zamindars were oppressing the poor farmers and peasants, who were mostly Muslim, then those farmers and peasants started to move away from their religion in thought of getting rid of their misery. The motive of Faraizi movement was to save religion of those people as well as ensure their proper rights as a human being. Haji Shariat Ullah wanted to make those peasants believe that all men are equal, and no one has the right to impose taxes on the almighty God's land (Sengupta, 2011). The movement promoted equality, fairness by opposing heavy taxes and unjust doing on the farmers. Shariat Ullah encouraged people to follow Islamic rule and resist the oppression peacefully (Ahmed, 2001).

The Faraizies refused to pay unfair and excessive taxes imposed on them by the Zamindars. They gathered farmers and peasants united them to rouse up against the landlords and British. Initially, Haji Shariat Ullah along with the experienced and faithful peasants established village court so that the villagers do not need to go to the British court and get biased judgements. After his death, his son Muhammad Mohsin, popular as Dudu Miyan, became

the leader of this movement. He made Bahadurpur his capital and divided the East Bengal into several Holkas with a Khalifa in charge of each of them. He made strict rule of not going to British government courts rather come to the courts which he and people with his ideology run. He targeted not only the Zamindars but also the Indigo planters for violence. In 1846, he burned the indigo factory of Panchar (Sengupta, 2011).

The main participants of this movement were mostly rural Muslims, poor farmers and peasants who were under the dominance of the Zamindars. At one point they became distinct from their religion. Haji Shariat Ullah and his son Muhsin inspired and showed them the righteous path. Religious awakening and promise of social justice had motivated them. Their collective resistance threatened the Zamindars and the British.

Government at that time were not happy with this movement. This movement faced fierce opposition from the Zamindars and the British officials. They took this movement as a threat to their socio-economic dominance. British took legal actions, arrested the leaders, in forms of repression. Even after all these the Faraizies did not stop their protests and standings against the cruelty. The Faraizi movement gained widespread support and laid the groundwork for future anti-colonial and agrarian movement (Ahmed, 2001).

The Faraizi Movement played an important role in fostering socio-religious consciousness among Bengali Muslims and challenging British colonial and feudal oppression. The focus on Islamic unity and peasant rights made the Faraizi Movement a key part of Bengal's resistance history, inspiring future struggles for social and political justice.

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Titumir's Rebellion

Titumir's Revolt led by Shridar-ul-Mujahideen Syed Mir Nisar Ali, fondly known as Titumir is another important landmark to be studied in the resistive history of colonial Bengal in first half of the nineteenth century against both British imperialism and the feudal system represented by the colonial overlords of Bengal region- the Zamindars. The rebellion represented the socio-economic plight of Bengali peasantry and colonialism together with an audacious assertion of the peasantry against exploitation (Islam, 2003).

Titumir was a man from a good Muslim family, and he practiced in accordance with Islamic principles. A charismatic CDE he achieved marvellous results through religious reform and socio-political activism. His leadership awoke because of the coloured exploitation of Bengali peasants especially the unpalatable taxes and forced labour levied on them by the local collaborating landlords, the zamindars in collaboration with the British East India Company. Titumir possessed magnetic personality and elimination of injustice worked as a symbol for the poor thus making Titumir an important entity in the history of Bengal (Rahman, 2011).

It was believed that the revolt aimed at dismantling the oppression of the zamindari's and protested the colonialization economic policies. 91 Titumir laid the ideology on Islamic reform and socio- economic justice for human dignity, equality and self-reliance. His movement sought to repeal laws that offended farmers, abolish oppressive taxation system, foster for a fair political regime which would not be dominated by colonizers (Ahmed, 2009).

Titumir and his followers used some tactics of self-defence as well as counterattack. To protect themselves from future British attacks they constructed the bamboo fort, Basher Kella in 1831 in Narkelberia village. Though it was made with mere mud and straw, the fort was a complex architecture pointing towards base and was capable enough of countering military attacks. It also included militancy and sought to overthrow the oppressors among the native landlords — zamindars — and fight the British army. But the rebellion most definitely reached the peak when the British began a massive army campaign. Titumir was killed and the fort was overrun but the revolt has written itself into the history of the region (Hardiman 1996).

It was mainly the Muslim peasant in the country areas who was oppressed by both the zamindari and British colonial policies of taxation. These peasants who are sometimes without land or any form of capital, politically and economically powerless saw the light and power in Titumir. It also 'awakened' artisans and small traders and all those people who were in search of a collective cause against oppression and to seek their rights (Rahman, 2011).

Titumir's revolt received resistance from two sides, the zamindars and the British colonial power. The zamindars being posed by the movement to their dominance became the tool with which the British extinguished the rebellion. Even in the failure the revolt sparked future resistance movements, it was a symbol of opposition Colonial and feudal oppression. Today Titumir has become the symbol of the fight for justice and equality as noted by Ahmed (2009).

Despite the failure of Titumir's revolt it has a place in the historical dictionary of revolutions against the British domination. The movement focusing on the plight of peasants in socio-economic terms and represented fight against oppression. Due to Titumir's leadership and vision, people fight for dignity and justice in Bengal history up to the present time (Islam, 2003).

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Indigo Revolt (Neel Bidroho)

Neel Bidroho, the Indigo Revolt of 1859-1860, was an important revolt of Bengalee peasants against the harsh inquisition by the high European indigo planters in British rule in India. It developed out of a revolt by exploited farmers who must grow indigo at disadvantageous rates, causing great economic and social suffering. It was an important turning point in the campaign against colonial exploitation and also a symbol of rural resistance (Chakrabarty, 1998).

It was the only act of Indigo Revolt that did not consist of a single central leader. But rather, local village heads, and small scale leaders were behind the spearheading of the communities. Peasants were at the forefront, but intellectuals like Dinabandhu Mitra contributed at the least documenting and disseminating awareness of the issue by writing his play Nil Darpan (Islam, 2003).

The revolt was to free peasants from the exploitative indigo system forced on European planters. Under unfair contracts, the planters forced the farmers to grow indigo on their best lands, paid them grudgingly and went into debt and destitution. The peasants wanted fair treatment, were entitled to free of forced cultivation, were allowed to grow crops of their own choice (Ahmed, 2009).

A combination of violent and non violent tactics was used in the revolt. Indigo was resisted by peasants; threats and physical coercion on the part of planter were met with refusal to

cultivate. They usually held village meetings and petitions against the planters' tyranny. Attacks on plantation offices and planters took place in some uprisings that went violent (Chakrabarty, 1998). The rebellion spread so quickly across Bengal that great pressure would soon be put upon the colonial administration.

The Indigo Revolt mainly concerned the unpaid small farmers most of whom were trapped into unfair contract with the planters. The latter was made up of peasant associations from Bengal, both Hindu and Muslim, who became concerned with the issues of economic and social justice affecting them as the stalwarths of the region's agrarian economy. At the same time, the movement received critical support from some sections of the middle class Bengalis being journalists, lawyers and playwrights who spoke for the peasants through newspapers and literature (Ahmed, 2009).

The Government of Britain for the first supported the European planters, then undertook violent tactics to control the rebellion. But soon the momentum of the movement started to build up and people's perception also started to change. Long before the indigo planters came under criticism due to various social reformers and intellectuals emphasizing the wrongs in the indigo system. Nil Darpan of Dinabandhu Mitra played a significant role in raising the voice against the exploitation of peasants and the heuristic dissemination of their issues (Islam, 2003).

The Indigo Revolt did not effect the change it aimed at as a whole, it obliged tapering of indigo cultivation in Bengal and gave the peasant the voice they needed. It also proved that ordinary farmers could rise up against their oppressors, and prompted uprisings by different

subsets of people throughout Bengal in the subsequent decades. It stands for endurance against structural power (Chakrabarty, 1998).

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The Chittagong Armory Raid and (Master Da) Surya Sen

One of the most bold revolution against British colonial power in subcontinent took place during the Chittagong Armory Raid of 1930 led by Master Da Surya Sen. It had been an integral part of the armed struggle for India's independence — it was devised to bring an end to British control in Chittagong, Bengal. The direct action of young revolutionaries expressed during this event, marked a turning point in the anti-colonial resistance (Chakrabarty, 1998).

Master Da, Surya Sen, had undergone a school education and became deeply influenced by the nationalist ideologies. He a member of the Indian Congress and later Jugantar group who believe in armed resistance to achieve independence. Banerjee (2000) argues Sen's strategic brilliance and charismatic leadership helped bind a bunch of young revolutionaries into a struggle face British imperialism.

They conducted the raid on the supposition that armed insurrection was necessary to bring an end to British rule. Surya Sen saw the raid as the start of a liberated zone in Chittagong. The chief goals involved disarranging Imperial pettiness over sequestering arms and ammunition, dismantling means of communication, and announcing independence in the aforementioned area (Rahman, 2011). These were the vision of a free India, sacrificed patriotism and the emphasis was on sacrifice.

This raid was perfect planning. Sen and his comrades succeeded in capturing weapons and blowing up communication lines in two armories in Chittagong on April 18, 1930. In order to

isolate Chittagong from the rest of British controlled Bengal they cut the telephone and telegraph wires. When the revolutionaries rose, they hoisted the Indian national flag, as a symbol of defiance (Chakrabarty, 1998). The raid was soon followed by a battle in the Jalalabad Hills with British forces, where the gang retreated. The revolutionaries were brave, considering they were outnumbered and in spite of being under equipped.

The participants were mainly young revolutionary students who were ardently nationalism motivated due to the given nature of the demonstrations. Some of them were Kalpana Dutta and Pritilata Waddadar who was a great asset for the movement. These participants had different social-economic status but they all aimed at freeing India from colonial masters (Banerjee, 2000).

The British government retaliated by using force to quell the rebellion putting in one of the worst acts of human rights abuses; using armed forces on unarmed citizens. Although the raid was not successful in accomplishing its short term goals and objectives it was established a good source of attention and boosted other forms of anti-colonial revolt. ASTE urged and got public support for Surya Sen and his comrades when they were arrested and put to trial. More essentially, Sen's execution in 1934 ensured his status as the independence martyr of India (Rahman, 2011).

The most dramatic events that illustrate the India's revolutionaries' spirit in their fight for freedom are described by Lex The Chittagong Armory Raid. While failing in its main aim of bringing about change of power from the British, it gave people the spirit and issue for people

to fight for independence. The leadership of master Da Surya Sen and the his companions are still memorized in India as the symbol of resistance (Banerjee, 2000).

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Tebhaga Movement and (Rani Ma) Ila Mitra

The Tebhaga Movement starting 1946 was perhaps the most important tape of agrarian uprising in Bengal. It was intended to guarantee two-thirds (tebhaga) of the crop for the tenant and one-third for the landlord against the existing arrangement that entitled the landlord to one-third while the tenant alternatively paid for one-third to the landlord. It sought to transform the pernicious system of sharecropping and the zamindari system, which are at the heart of the struggle for agrarian justice in colonial and early post colonial Bengal. Ranjita Prasad Mitra popularly known as Rani Ma was one of the most effective leaders of this movement which symbolised the peasant's ethos vis-à-vis the British empire (Chatterjee, 1997).

However, any narration of the Tebhaga movement must submit to the misogynistic rule that Ila Mitra, the curtain raiser of the movement, a revolutionary leader and social reformation personality, had to be an honourable mention. Being a daughter of a Bengali business tycoon Ila Mitra was well educated and politically inclined and was a member of the Communist Party of India since her years of youth. It was her passion and concern towards the problems of farmers mostly in the rural areas as well as women. Ila Mitra mobilised and galvanised peasants in Rajshahi district (present-day Bangladesh) which made her a prominent anti-feudalism activist (Banerjee, 2001).

Tebhaga movement had its link with the Communism slogan of land reform and peasants. It aimed at liberation of tenant farmers by ensuring from the start that they receive a certain portion of the crops they grew. It sought to remove the intermediaries (jotedars and

zamindars) and led directly to benefit the tillers of the soil. It provided for larger aims of realizing agrarian reform and fighting against the feudal structure keeping poverty and injustice alive (Chatterjee, 1997).

It incorporated both legal and illegal strategies of action, what characterized the movement. The tenant farmers protested, refused to deliver crops to their landlords, and grew crops on the landlords' land. Ila Mitra played a vital role to bring women and to involve them into this process actively. What started as a protest soon gathers momentum and further police agitation failed to deter the movement from spreading across Bengal; peasants here were protesting against the forced rents and taxes being imposed on them. The CPI offered the organisation format and direction to build the movement (Mukherjee, 2004).

Share croppers and landless peasants were the key populations regarded as participants in the study most of whom hailed from the lower castes. Under Ila Mitra, women found a place in shaping the society through rejecting s rural female entrenched stereotype lifestyle and norms. These farmers, who were enticed by fair share of their sweat in their produce, were not passive to oppression and indeed played a positive role in the growth and sustenance of the movement (Banerjee, 2001).

Brahmized leaders of the movement suffered harsh repression from the zamindars, the police and the British colonial government that feared any form of peasant revolt. The wife of an intellectual, Ila Mitra herself was arrested, tortured and imprisoned but she iconised the struggle and strength. Tebhaga uprising called fellow peasant movements in India and even the village based farmer's consciousness (Mukherjee, 2004).

Perhe was however crushed after few months but The Tebhaga Movement showed everyone that there was need of Agrarian reforms together with justice in tenant farmer. The peasant rights movement in Bengal would not be the same today had Ila Mitra not take the leadership and made the necessary sacrifices. It still symbolises the struggle against oppression and marginalisation, as well as the struggle for decent treatment and recognition (Chatterjee, 1997, p 60).

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